DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

2.4 Slave Narratives

After gaining their freedom, some former slaves wrote about their experiences and the cruelty they'd endured. They wanted to open up people's eyes to the true nature of slavery.



Engraving of Olaudah Equiano from his book, *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano*

Olaudah Equiano (oh-LOW-duh ehk-wee-AHN-oh) was born in Benin, an empire in Africa that you have learned about previously. Equiano was sold into slavery at the age of 11. About 10 years later, he bought his freedom from his last owner, a Quaker from Philadelphia. He made his way to England, where he lectured on the evils of slavery.

In 1789, in London, Equiano published his autobiography, an excerpt from which appears on the next page. He had the image shown here created for the book. Copies sold quickly, and the popularity of *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano* contributed to a law being passed in England in 1807 that made slavery illegal in England and its colonies. By then, as you will learn, America was no longer a British colony.

CRITICAL VIEWING Why do you think Equiano wanted to have his portrait show him holding a book?

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DOCUMENT ONE

Primary Source: Autobiography
from *The Interesting Narrative of the Life of Olaudah Equiano*, 1789

In this excerpt from his autobiography, Equiano describes the brutal conditions aboard the slave ship during the passage from Africa to the Americas—the notorious Middle Passage.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE What details help you understand the horror the slaves endured in the Middle Passage?

I was soon put down under the decks, and there I received such a salutation [greeting] in my nostrils as I had never experienced in my life: so that, with the loathsomeness of the stench [smell], and crying together, I became so sick and low that I was not able to eat, nor had I the least desire to taste any thing.

. . . Many a time we were near suffocation from the want [lack] of fresh air, which we were often without for whole days together. This, and the stench of the necessary tubs, carried off [killed] many.

DOCUMENT TWO

Primary Source: Autobiography
from *A Narrative of the Most Remarkable Particulars in the Life of James Albert Ukawsaw Gronniosaw, An African Prince, as Related by Himself*, 1772

James Albert Ukawsaw Gronniosaw was sold into slavery at age 15. Upset with his family, Gronniosaw had believed the promise of a slave merchant and voluntarily left his home in Africa. He realized his mistake too late.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE How does the merchant make the idea of going with him sound like a fascinating adventure rather than the entry into a nightmare?

About this time there came a merchant from the Gold Coast. . . . He told me that if I would go with him I should see houses with wings to them walk upon the water, and should also see the white folks; and that he had many sons of my age, which should be my companions; and he added to all this that he would bring me safe back again soon. I was highly pleased with the account of this strange place, and was very desirous of going.

DOCUMENT THREE

Primary Source: Autobiography
from *A Narrative of the Life and Adventures of Venture, a Native of Africa: But Resident Above Sixty Years in the United States of America*, 1798

Venture Smith was born in West Africa, captured as a young child by an enemy army, and then sold as a slave in Rhode Island. He published his autobiography in 1798. The excerpt details how he obtained freedom for his family.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE What can you infer about the personal qualities that enabled Venture Smith to accomplish all that he describes?

Being thirty-six years old, I left Col. Smith once for all . . . [having] paid an enormous sum for my freedom. . . . When I had [raised enough money to purchase] my two sons, I had then left more than one hundred pounds. . . . The rest of my money I laid out in land, in addition to a farm which I owned before, and a dwelling house thereon . . . [In] my forty-fourth year, I purchased my wife Meg . . . Being about forty-six years old, I bought my oldest child Hannah . . . I had already redeemed from slavery, myself, my wife and three children.

SYNTHESIZE & WRITE

1. **REVIEW** Review what you have learned about the slave trade and slavery in colonial America.
2. **RECALL** On your own paper, write the main ideas expressed in each document.
3. **CONSTRUCT** Construct a topic sentence that answers this question: How did formerly enslaved persons endure and overcome slavery?
4. **WRITE** Using evidence from this chapter and the documents, write an informative paragraph that supports your topic sentence in Step 3.

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